

MAGAZINE

to eat or not to
eat - question

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Eat Like a Child

"Again?!" I mumbled, replacing the lid on the food my grandmother was cooking. She'd made her "signature" meal: stewed fish, lentils, rice, and a bit of watercress. While healthy and nourishing, it was also a meal on rotation almost every week. We weren't rich, but to my young mind Dominoes was always an option if there was nothing else to eat. To my immigrant grandmother, you ate what was provided or you went hungry. Sighing in second-generational entitlement, I backed away from the stove, opting for cereal. Yes, I preferred the highly processed sugary grain I considered food to the home cooking my grandmother provided. Today, I'd give anything for that meal again.

As a child, I had a (somewhat) irrational fear of a fish bone getting stuck in my throat or rubbing my eyes and getting scotch bonnet pepper in my eye. My grandmother made bujol—salted cod with freshly baked coconut bread that was both amazing and dicey to my young mind. I'd had the experience of getting a small bone stuck in my throat and vowed never again. No matter how tasty, I'll stick to the fish sticks. Again, my grandmother said eat it or go hungry.



Today, I'd give anything for that meal again.

Diaspora parents constantly have to go to war between tradition and modernity. How does one teach respect for culture? There are generations of kids who've been tormented for bringing "funky" food to school and subsequently not fitting in. What does "American" food taste like? I would argue it tastes like a conglomerate of recipes from immigrants. A hodgepodge of history confined to the local ingredients available to them. To "fit in" is to lose the roots of that culture. Instead of the cod, maybe just have a simple salmon with some lemon on it. My grandmother would say it wasn't cost effective, and if it wasn't broke...don't fix it.



Today, I seek out that food and the stories that pair well with what's being served. The nostalgia hits when curry burns in the pot. The sizzle of the chicken hitting hot oil in the pan. I hear the calypso playing on the radio in the kitchen as my eyes water from the spices in the air. My grandmother would hum along as she moved about the kitchen, singing the songs of her people. My mom has some of that, but she may go for frozen instead of fresh utilizing modern conveniences. Unlike my grandmother who would go to the market smelling the fresh produce looking for the choicest options. She would argue that there were no shortcuts to quality ingredients.

"What do you want for Christmas?" My mom asked this past December. I want my granny's Sunday dinner with all the fixings. I want the stewed chicken, macaroni pie, callaloo, fried plantains, and coleslaw with a bit of watercress. I want to be hugged by my granny again. I want the culture of her people to permeate my being so my future kids don't forget the importance of these stories and her food. I'll take the fish bones, the hot pepper, and smelly stigmas. I was born in the US but thanks to my grandmother and her food, I am Trini to de bone.